

Which is something like judgment day: don't lie to the extent that "tall, fair and slim" becomes "short, dark and fat."

With the privacy the Internet gives you, it's hard to resist, though. We'd all like to be beautiful people.

"FUNCTION FATIGUE"

Too Many Features

Remember those simple mobile phones that just let you speak? Like the Nokia 1100? That's what people want, it seems, according to a survey by FAME. Well, that's human nature for you.

FAME is the Forum to Advance the Mobile Experience, and the survey was sponsored in part by Palm. Now, if FAME wants to Advance the Mobile Experience, it turns out they don't have to do much—just tell people to revert to the phones of a decade ago!

They're calling it "Function Fatigue": it was the #1 complaint of those surveyed, and it means, "I

Pinch Me, I Must Be....Whoops!

If you've ever glanced at Brother Zivalal's midsection, you can see that life has been good to him—well, except for all the work we give him. Overall though, the sight conjures up the image of a ripe pumpkin. And then came the day that The Browne (who has now insisted on the moniker Vandal) decided to see how ripe it really was...

'Twas the night before closing, and the Vandalising Forefinger was on the prowl. As Zivalal browsed the file server, said forefinger sprung out of seemingly nowhere and struck him right in the pumpkin belly. Startled by the arrival of this unknown appendage, he mistakenly dragged the folder containing the magazine's Quark files into an undisclosed

location—files, mind you, crucial to this magazine ever getting printed.

"I don't know where it went! He did it! It's not my fault! I'm mailing Deepak! [miscellaneous expletives]!" And as Pillaiji and FatBeing suffered the fallout of the explosion, Vandal struggled to see through his tears of laughter.

After some careful forensic analysis at the scene of the crime (viz. Asking Sivalal to point out what exactly he was doing at the precise moment), the errant folder was tracked down, peace was restored, and eyes were rolled at Vandal's indiscretions. "All I did was *this*", he defends himself to anyone who'll listen (and many who won't)—unleashing the forefinger upon them. So if you ever get poked in the near future....

DIGIT DIARY

don't know how to use my phone." Dave Murray, director of FAME, puts it a little more eloquently and correctly: "There are too many product features that consumers don't use, or don't know how to use, and it frustrates them."

"There is a high percentage of consumers who are only looking for limited functionality," Murray says. "At the same time, there are many who

want more functionality. But they want to be able to actually use it."

In other words, some people want to use advanced features without knowing how to use them. That's human nature for you again. If you're going to cram a digital SLR into a cell phone, there's precious little you can do to simplify things. What are manufacturers to make of these findings, and what are they to do?

An interactive voice system would be welcome. "What do you want to do?" "Take a photo." "Is it bright or dark in here?" "Dark."

Seriously, we've seen too many reports of people complaining their devices are too hard to use, and we all know at the same time that people want to be able to do more. Perhaps someday everyone will actually get down to RTFM. ■

Blog WATCH

Apple's mess-up on DRM-free music was the hottest topic of the month—did Steve Jobs make a dumb move or will he become a worldwide hero? Also, it seems that JavaScript "things" do more harm than good

Mark Cuban

www.blogmaverick.com/2007/02/07/what-should-the-music-biz-do-next

What should the music biz do next?

...Does anyone question the interdependency of value among all outlets of music? Does the popularity of downloads of a song, its ring tone, its video, its CD sales, even ticket sales, licensing, sponsorships and merch sales affect the other elements? The total revenue available from the artist? Of course it does. Leverage Google, Yahoo, maybe even Microsoft or Amazon or others to create a system that takes input from all revenue sources and prices (with constraints as defined by the owner of the content, ie min/max price for a product, and/or break even point in net margin dollars for an artist or the entire label) to optimize whatever the goals of the company are, whether its overall sales/profitability, or possibly, maximizing the number of downloads and visibility for an artist...

Ed Felton

www.freedom-to-tinker.com/?p=1117

Apple Offers to Sell DRM-Free Music

...Much as I would like to see Apple renounce DRM entirely, that's not quite what Jobs is saying. The letter describes three possible futures for Apple's music technology: (1) continue the current path with a closed Apple-only DRM

system; (2) license Apple's DRM technology to other companies to build compatible systems; and (3) sell DRM-free music.

Apple's preferred outcome, Jobs says, is outcome (3). This is notable, and somewhat surprising, as the consensus has been that Apple strategy has been to seek outcome (1). If Apple really prefers to eliminate DRM, that is news...

Jerem Zowdany

<http://jeremy.zawodny.com/blog/archives/008547.html>

JavaScript Badges and Widgets Considered Harmful

... the seemingly ubiquitous JavaScript Badges/Widgets/Thingies that you see on blogs and web sites everywhere. Heck, I even have one on my site right now (over there--on the right)...

...Why? They're a hack. With all the talk of how the web has "become writable" with advent of blogs and self-publishing tools, you'd think that we'd have a better way of getting third party content on to our sites. Given that an overwhelming number of sites that are likely running PHP or some other "dynamic" hosting setup, these least common denominator solutions just feel wrong. (This could easily be followed by a rant on problems with the spread of web services and RSS.)...